

Tidy Gardens (Fife)

I have been trading as Tidy Gardens since 2000 and as the business grew we have met with criticism of having vehicles (cars and vans) parking on the main road. We have been reported to Fife Council on several occasions and on each occasion it has been agreed that we are not doing anything wrong, or illegal and that obviously we try to minimise the number of vehicles on the road.

It has to be said that the main number of complaints come from parents dropping off and picking up children from the school. Generally speaking there are few, if any of our vans there at those times, other than if we have had a late start or early finish, resulting from bad weather.

About 10 years ago we agreed with the Council to maintain the level of vans to the 7 we had at that time, which we have stuck to.

Since then, at least 5 vans are taken home by the drivers at night, so there are usually only 2 which are parked in front our house, Fairbairn House overnight. During a normal working day at least 5 or 6 of the vans are away from 8.20/8.30am until 6.00/6.30pm. During the Nov- Feb they obviously are back earlier, depending on day light.

We have up to 18 gardeners and during the working days Mon/Tues/Wed, 3 of the men park on the Main Street, 1 opposite the old pub carpark and 2 beyond the zigzag lines at the school. Thurs/Friday there is usually only one car, beyond the zigzag lines and none further down. Other members of staff tend to get picked up to save on the parking issues.

I should point out that, especially in the afternoons when the children are being picked up, it can be chaotic with cars and taxis filling up the street, as they tend to start arriving from 2.30pm. In the morning it tends to be more spread out.

The school can have a number of teachers cars parked on the street as well. There are quite a number of Peripatetic teachers visit the school over the week too.

We are very aware of the problems and the complaints on Facebook etc. but people seem to blame Tidy Gardens for it all but that is not the case. Over the years, very few people have ever contacted us regarding the problems, it would obviously be much easier if they did, as we are only ever aware if someone tells us about a Facebook comment.

Obviously, during the winter months our start and finishing times can vary and we do try to avoid school times where possible, but we have a business to run and we are ruled by the weather.

We do take our responsibilities seriously and try to do things for the community. We look after the grounds at the Village Hall free of charge on a regular basis, we have donated to the recent crowd funding for the Village Hall and, I also run Whist Drives to raise funds for the hall. If the School has any fund-raising activities, we support those too.